```
$ which php8.4
/usr/bin/php8.4
```

In fact /usr/bin/php isn't a binary at all but a Linux filesystem symbolic link (symlink):

```
$ ls -la /usr/bin/ | grep php
lrwxrwxrwx  1 root root         21 Jul  3 17:39 php -> /etc/
alternatives/php
-rwxr-xr-x  1 root root    4850696 Jul  3 17:39 php7.4
-rwxr-xr-x  1 root root    6070784 Aug  3 09:48 php8.4
```

Notice that /usr/bin/php links to /etc/alternatives/php. The Debian alternatives system allows for easy switching of default programs. Let's change the default from 8.4 to 7.4.

```
$ sudo update-alternatives --set php /usr/bin/php7.4
update-alternatives: using /usr/bin/php7.4 to provide /usr/bin/php (php) in
manual mode
```

```
$ php -v
PHP 7.4.33 (cli) (built: Jul  3 2025 16:39:22) ( NTS )
```

When it comes to juggling versions Debian's alternatives is pretty good, but there are other ways to achieve the same end. We will be exploring the use of Docker shortly.

With DNF

DNF (Dandified YUM) is an evolution of Yum, which has been the main package management utility of Redhat-based systems for many years. Using `dnf` at the command line is much like using `yum`, and indeed some distributions (usually truncated to *distro*) simply symlink `yum` to the `dnf` binary. We'll use the Fedora distro for the following DNF examples.

Like other package managers, `dnf install php` will give you the latest stable release for the version of the OS you are using, if you want to use earlier versions then it is necessary to add a repository. In the case of Redhat based systems this will be Remi's repository – https://rpms.remirepo.net/ – which contains vast amounts of installable resources for the PHP stack on these platforms. The repository is added with a